

BUILT TO LAST

A Biblical Marriage Study for Couples

12 Weeks of Scripture, Discussion, and Growth
for Husbands and Wives Together

By Daniel Tesfamariam

BUILT TO LAST - A Biblical Marriage Study for Couples

Copyright 2025 Daniel Tesfamariam

All rights reserved.

Scripture quotations are from the public domain (KJV).

No part of this publication may be reproduced without permission.

WEEK 1: THE FOUNDATION - What God Intended for Marriage

Scripture: Genesis 2:18-25

READ TOGETHER:

'And the Lord God said, It is not good that the man should be alone;
I will make him an help meet for him... Therefore shall a man leave his
father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall
be one flesh.' - Genesis 2:18, 24 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What does 'leave and cleave' mean practically for us today?
2. How do we maintain 'one flesh' unity when life gets busy?
3. What outside influences threaten our unity as a couple?
4. How can we better prioritize our marriage above other relationships?

APPLY:

This week, identify one area where an outside influence is competing with your marriage. Discuss a boundary you can set together.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Lord, help us return to Your original design for marriage. Show us where we have let other things come between us. Make us truly one.

WEEK 1 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

What is one way I can show my wife she is my first priority this week?

FOR HER:

What is one way I can show my husband he is my first priority this week?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Go on a 'no phone' date this week. Give each other undivided attention.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 2: LOVE THAT SERVES - Christ's Example for Husbands

Scripture: Ephesians 5:25-33

READ TOGETHER:

'Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church,
and gave himself for it.' - Ephesians 5:25 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What does sacrificial love look like in daily marriage life?
2. Husband: In what ways do you find it hardest to serve your wife?
3. Wife: When do you feel most loved and served by your husband?
4. How is Christ's love for the church a model we can actually follow?

APPLY:

Husband: Ask your wife, 'What is one thing I can do this week that would make you feel deeply loved?' Then do it without complaint.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Father, give husbands the strength to love sacrificially. Help us see service as strength, not weakness. Shape us into Your image.

WEEK 2 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

Where am I being selfish in my marriage? What would sacrificial love look like in that area?

FOR HER:

Am I making it easy or hard for my husband to love me well? How can I receive his love more openly?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Husband: Do one task your wife normally does without being asked. Wife: Express specific gratitude for his service.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 3: RESPECT AND HONOR - Building Each Other Up

Scripture: Ephesians 5:33, 1 Peter 3:7

READ TOGETHER:

'Nevertheless let every one of you in particular so love his wife even as himself; and the wife see that she reverence her husband.'

- Ephesians 5:33 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What does respect look like vs. what does disrespect look like?
2. How do we show honor to each other in front of others?
3. When have you felt most respected/disrespected by your spouse?
4. How can we disagree while still maintaining honor?

APPLY:

Each day this week, find one specific thing to praise about your spouse - say it out loud, in front of others if possible.

PRAY TOGETHER:

God, guard our tongues from criticism and contempt. Fill our mouths with words that build up. Help us see the best in each other.

WEEK 3 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

Do I speak about my wife with respect when she is not in the room? What needs to change?

FOR HER:

Do I communicate respect to my husband in the ways HE receives it? What does respect look like to him?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Write 5 things you respect about your spouse and read the list to them tonight.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 4: COMMUNICATION - Speaking the Truth in Love

Scripture: Ephesians 4:15, 25-32

READ TOGETHER:

'But speaking the truth in love, may grow up into him in all things...
Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which
is good to the use of edifying.' - Ephesians 4:15, 29 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What is the difference between honesty and harshness?
2. What communication patterns damage our connection?
3. When is it hardest for us to communicate well?
4. How can we create a safe space for vulnerable conversation?

APPLY:

Practice the Speaker-Listener technique: One person speaks for 2 minutes
without interruption, then the listener reflects back what they heard.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Holy Spirit, guard our words. Help us listen to understand, not to
respond. Give us courage to be honest and grace to be gentle.

WEEK 4 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

What topic have I been avoiding that we need to discuss? What am I afraid will happen if I bring it up?

FOR HER:

What topic have I been avoiding that we need to discuss? What am I afraid will happen if I bring it up?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Have a 15-minute 'State of Our Marriage' conversation. No phones, no distractions, no defensiveness.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 5: FORGIVENESS - Releasing the Debt

Scripture: Colossians 3:12-14, Matthew 18:21-22

READ TOGETHER:

'And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.' - Ephesians 4:32 (KJV)

'Then came Peter to him, and said, Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times? Jesus saith unto him, I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven.'
- Matthew 18:21-22 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What does biblical forgiveness actually require of us?
2. Is there any unresolved hurt between us that needs attention?
3. How do we forgive without enabling repeated harmful behavior?
4. What is the difference between forgiveness and trust?

APPLY:

If there is a lingering hurt, bring it to each other this week with 'I felt hurt when... I choose to forgive... I need... going forward.'

PRAY TOGETHER:

Father, we have been forgiven so much. Help us extend that same grace to each other. Heal old wounds and give us fresh starts.

WEEK 5 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

Is there anything I am holding onto that I need to release? Am I punishing my wife for past mistakes?

FOR HER:

Is there anything I am holding onto that I need to release? Am I punishing my husband for past mistakes?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Write each other a letter of forgiveness for a past hurt. Exchange them and burn them together as a symbol of release.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 6: INTIMACY - More Than Physical

Scripture: Song of Solomon 2:10-13, 1 Corinthians 7:3-5

READ TOGETHER:

'My beloved spake, and said unto me, Rise up, my love, my fair one,
and come away. For, lo, the winter is past, the rain is over and gone.'

- Song of Solomon 2:10-11 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What are the different types of intimacy (emotional, spiritual, physical)?
2. Which type of intimacy do we need to strengthen most right now?
3. What barriers exist to deeper intimacy between us?
4. How can we create more space for connection in our busy lives?

APPLY:

Schedule 3 intentional moments of connection this week: one emotional
(deep conversation), one spiritual (pray together), one physical
(non-sexual touch).

PRAY TOGETHER:

Lord, deepen our intimacy in every dimension. Remove the barriers we have
built. Help us be fully known and fully loved.

WEEK 6 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

What makes me feel closest to my wife? Have I told her? What is one thing I can do to make her feel emotionally safe?

FOR HER:

What makes me feel closest to my husband? Have I told him? What is one thing I can do to make him feel desired and appreciated?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Hold hands and pray together every night this week before sleep - even if it is just one sentence each.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 7: FINANCES - Stewardship Together

Scripture: Proverbs 3:9-10, Luke 16:10-11

READ TOGETHER:

'Honour the Lord with thy substance, and with the firstfruits of all thine increase: So shall thy barns be filled with plenty.' - Proverbs 3:9-10 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What money habits did we each bring from our families of origin?
2. Are we unified in our financial decisions or do we operate separately?
3. What financial stress is affecting our marriage right now?
4. How can we better honor God with our finances as a team?

APPLY:

Sit down together and review your budget (or create one). Pray over your finances and decide on one financial goal to pursue together.

PRAY TOGETHER:

God, You own it all. Help us be faithful stewards together. Remove financial stress and help us trust You with our provision.

WEEK 7 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

Am I being transparent about all spending? Is there any financial secret I need to confess?

FOR HER:

Am I being transparent about all spending? Is there any financial secret I need to confess?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Create a shared financial goal and put a visual tracker somewhere you both see daily.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 8: PARENTING AS A TEAM

Scripture: Proverbs 22:6, Deuteronomy 6:6-7

READ TOGETHER:

'Train up a child in the way he should go; and when he is old, he will not depart from it.' - Proverbs 22:6 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. Are we on the same page with discipline and expectations?
2. Do our children see us as a united team or do they divide us?
3. How do we protect our marriage while raising children?
4. What values are we intentionally passing to our children?

APPLY:

Identify one area where you are not on the same page with parenting.
Discuss privately (never in front of children) and agree on a unified approach.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Father, help us raise our children with wisdom and unity. Protect our marriage from being consumed by parenting. Give us Your wisdom.

WEEK 8 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

Am I an engaged father? Where can I step up in leading our family spiritually?

FOR HER:

Am I supporting my husband's role as father? Where can I encourage him more?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

If applicable, have a family meeting to discuss one family value and how you will all live it out this week.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 9: CONFLICT - Fighting Fair

Scripture: Proverbs 15:1, James 1:19-20

READ TOGETHER:

'A soft answer turneth away wrath: but grievous words stir up anger.'

- Proverbs 15:1 (KJV)

'Wherefore, my beloved brethren, let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath.' - James 1:19 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What are our unhealthy conflict patterns (stonewalling, yelling, etc.)?
2. What triggers escalation in our disagreements?
3. How can we fight FOR our marriage instead of against each other?
4. What 'rules of engagement' should we agree on?

APPLY:

Create your own 'Fair Fighting Rules' together. Write them down, sign them, and post them where you can both see them.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Lord, help us fight fair. When we disagree, remind us we are on the same team. Give us self-control and grace under pressure.

WEEK 9 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

What is my default in conflict (fight, flight, freeze)? How does that affect my wife?

FOR HER:

What is my default in conflict (fight, flight, freeze)? How does that affect my husband?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Agree on a 'time-out' signal. When either of you uses it, take 20 minutes apart, then come back calmly.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 10: SPIRITUAL LEADERSHIP - Growing Together in Faith

Scripture: Joshua 24:15, Acts 2:42

READ TOGETHER:

'But as for me and my house, we will serve the Lord.' - Joshua 24:15 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What does spiritual leadership in the home look like to each of you?
2. Are we growing in faith together or separately?
3. What spiritual disciplines can we practice as a couple?
4. How can we serve together outside our home?

APPLY:

Choose one spiritual discipline to practice together this week: praying together, reading Scripture together, serving together, or fasting together.

PRAY TOGETHER:

God, draw us closer to You and to each other. Help us lead our home with faith and humility. Use our marriage for Your glory.

WEEK 10 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

Am I leading spiritually with humility? What one step can I take to grow in spiritual leadership?

FOR HER:

Am I supporting and encouraging spiritual growth? How can I make space for us to grow together?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Start a couples devotional routine - even 5 minutes a day reading one verse and praying together.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 11: SEASONS OF MARRIAGE - Enduring Through Change

Scripture: Ecclesiastes 3:1-8, Romans 8:28

READ TOGETHER:

'To every thing there is a season, and a time to every purpose under the heaven.' - Ecclesiastes 3:1 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What season is our marriage in right now (newlywed, young kids, empty nest, crisis)?
2. What has been the hardest season we have faced together?
3. How has our marriage grown through difficulty?
4. What season do we want to prepare for next?

APPLY:

Name the current season of your marriage honestly. Discuss what this season needs from each of you and from God.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Father, thank You for sustaining us through every season. Give us eyes to see Your faithfulness and hope for what is ahead.

WEEK 11 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

What does my wife need from me in THIS season that may be different from past seasons?

FOR HER:

What does my husband need from me in THIS season that may be different from past seasons?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Look at your wedding photos together. Share what you remember feeling that day and recommit to that love.

How did the challenge go?

WEEK 12: LEGACY - The Marriage You Are Building

Scripture: Psalm 127:1, Proverbs 13:22

READ TOGETHER:

'Except the Lord build the house, they labour in vain that build it.'

- Psalm 127:1 (KJV)

'A good man leaveth an inheritance to his children's children.'

- Proverbs 13:22 (KJV)

DISCUSS:

1. What kind of marriage legacy do we want to leave for our children/grandchildren?
2. What did our parents' marriages teach us (good and bad)?
3. What would we want people to say about our marriage in 50 years?
4. How can we be an example to other couples around us?

APPLY:

Write a Marriage Mission Statement together: 'Our marriage exists to...'

Keep it to 1-2 sentences. Display it in your home.

PRAY TOGETHER:

Lord, build our house. Let our marriage bring You glory and point others to Your love. Help us leave a legacy of faithfulness.

WEEK 12 - INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

FOR HIM:

What kind of husband do I want to be remembered as? What needs to change now to become that man?

FOR HER:

What kind of wife do I want to be remembered as? What needs to change now to become that woman?

WEEKLY CHALLENGE:

Write your Marriage Mission Statement and post it where you will see it daily.

How did the challenge go?

RENEWAL OF VOWS

After 12 weeks of study, write new vows to each other reflecting what you have learned and how you want to love going forward.

HIS VOWS TO HER:

HER VOWS TO HIM:

Date of renewal: __/__/__ Witnessed by: _____

OUR MARRIAGE VISION

Use this page to capture your shared vision for your marriage.

OUR MARRIAGE MISSION STATEMENT:

IN 1 YEAR, WE WANT OUR MARRIAGE TO:

IN 5 YEARS, WE WANT OUR MARRIAGE TO:

IN 25 YEARS, WE WANT OUR MARRIAGE TO:

THE LEGACY WE WANT TO LEAVE:

**'Two are better than one; because they have a good reward
for their labour.' - Ecclesiastes 4:9**